

[Return to Search](#)

Words and the Dogon world

Author(S): Calame-Griaule, Geneviève, LaPin, Deirdre

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 305

Culture (OWC): [Dogon \(FA16\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1946-1960

Coverage Date: 1946-1960

Place Coverage: Mopti Region, Mali

Section Title(S): Expansion And Conservation Of Speech

Certain languages, contiguous to Dogon country, are spoken by the Dogon in these border regions. This is the case with Soninke, the language of Marka people, part of the Mandaic language group having similarities with eastern and southeastern Dogon. There are numerous Marka villages in the cantons of Bongoudie, Tori, Diallaye, and Koumounouri.³² The case is the same for Samogho (the widespread Dyoula name for San), which is also part of the Mandaic group and is spoken particularly in the canton of Pana. As for the Mossi, they have always had religious and cultural contacts with their Dogon neighbors. As Zahan states, "Even today, there are villages in the heart of the Yatenga region where the Dogon carry out priestly functions for the Mossi. The Mossi-Dogon religious symbiosis is so strong that neither group feels uncomfortable, for instance, about the fact that the Dogon make regular sacrifices to tenga (a Mossi altar dedicated to the earth) on the léwé (a Dogon altar, also dedicated to the earth). Many similar examples lead to the supposition that these two groups share the same cultural values" (1950:229). Dogon who understand mō:re (the Mossi language) are rather rare today, however, except for those who have traveled in Mossi country; only the "Plains Dogon" living near the Mossi speak their language and are understood by them.

000

Material Not Relevant

177

Acculturation And
Culture Contact

191

Speech

782

Prayers And Sacrifices

Bozo is a rather different case, and although the Dogon themselves do not speak it, they accord it primary importance.³³ Dogon contacts with these fishermen of the Niger River are based less on trade than on shared features of social and religious organization (see Dieterlen and Calame-Griaule 1960:51). Indeed, these two people are joined in a "joking relationship" or "cathartic association,"³⁴ called má[unavailable]u in Dogon from má[unavailable]a which means to "knead into a ball." According to Griaule this

000

Material Not Relevant

177

Acculturation And
Culture Contact

relationship gives rise to several forms of exchange of "material, moral and religious services rendered: hospitality, the administering of food and of purification, and ritual activities" (1948a:243). The relationship also gives rise to various taboos chiefly concerning sexual relationships, spilled  blood, and release of tension through taunts and insults.³⁵ The Dogon use of the Bozo tongue is limited to certain insults on the subject of food and sexual parts, while the Bozo, for their part, make use of the same insults.

32. For the location of these villages, see the map in Calame-Griaule 1956.

33. The Bozo or Sorogo people, renowned fishermen, inhabit the Djénne region on the banks of the Nihon Niger River at Lake Debo. Their language belongs to the Mandaic group, but it seems to be an archaic dialect in the process of disappearing, as an entire sector of the Bozo population has abandoned the language for Bambara. The Bozo people are polyglots since other Sudanic peoples characteristically do not speak their language, finding the consonants too difficult to pronounce.

34. The terminology is from Marcel Griaule.

35. The workings of this institution will be examined in Part III, Chapter 3, "The Expression of Aggression: Taunts, Insults, and their Cathartic Value."

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)